them difficult to govern. Three characteristics of agentic systems create this challenge:

- **Dynamic planning**—agents decide which actions to take at runtime.
- **Tool-based execution**—agents rely on external tools that may access sensitive data or systems.
- **Adaptive behavior**—agents revise their plans as they gather new information.

These are not edge cases. They are defining properties of agentic systems. Together, these characteristics mean that authorization can no longer rely on static assumptions about how software will operate. Each action must be evaluated in the context in which it occurs.

In this sense, authorization in agentic systems becomes a natural extension of Zero Trust principles. Instead of assuming an application will behave as intended, the system continuously evaluates each action the agent proposes, verifying that it complies with policy under current conditions.

At ACME, this led to a shift from treating authorization as a gate at the edge of an application to embedding it directly into the agent's runtime decision-making process. Before invoking a tool or accessing data, the agent constructs a request describing the action it plans to take, which ACME's policy engine evaluates using the same enterprise policy infrastructure that governs the rest of its systems.

Agents did not receive their own authorization system. Instead, they operated under the same policy architecture that governed the rest of ACME's software systems. While the governance process and tooling were the same, the policies were adapted to control agent behavior, emphasizing tool use, delegation, and runtime constraints instead of the static workflows common in traditional applications.

Trudy summarized the change like this: "In traditional systems, authorization answers the question Can this application access this resource? With agents, the question becomes Is this action safe for the agent to perform right now?" In other words, agentic systems turn authorization from a static configuration problem into a continuous governance challenge.